was that if such is the rhetoric when the US has not withdrawn, then what will happen when one year later?'[61]

On 27–28 October 2009, during an official visit to London, foreign secretary Nirupama Rao met with her British counterpart FCO permanent undersecretary Peter Ricketts. Behind the glare of the media, Rao politely but forcefully expressed India's 'strong reservations' about the UK policy of reconciliation with the moderate Taliban elements.[62] With a timeline for withdrawal taking rounds, Rao argued that the moderate Taliban would engage in negotiations with the strategic objective of waiting for the West to leave and then the radical elements would assert themselves. Ricketts rubbished Rao's concerns. He countered that the UK had a great deal of experience dealing with insurgencies, and 'there comes a point when you need to engage by political means'. Soon after the disastrous meeting, the FCO requested the US to urge a 'pragmatic' Manmohan Singh to 'support reconciliation with moderate Taliban elements ... and Pakistan'.[63] To buttress the reconciliation process with economic incentives, the West brokered meetings between Kabul and Islamabad to sign the Afghanistan-Pakistan Transit Trade Agreement (APTTA) and increase bilateral trade that stood at US$832 million in 2006. The agreement had gone through several stages of negotiations and entailed duty-free trade between the two countries. The thorn in the agreement, expectedly, was India. The Afghans wanted access to Indian markets but Pakistan would not allow that.[64] All Afghan trucks would have to unload at the India-Pakistan border at Wagah, and reload the goods into Indian trucks for onward passage. It made little economic sense for Afghanistan to sign an agreement that would not connect them with the 'jackpot' of South Asia's largest market.[65] Still, with reconciliation and withdrawal in view, London (and Washington) lobbied hard in December 2009 for the accord to be signed (only to be met with staunch rebuttals from Kabul). It was 'perfidy' lamented an Indian diplomat closely following the events from Kabul.[66]

'The second deception'

On 28 January 2010, representatives from more than seventy countries convened at the Lancaster House in London for a conference on Afghanistan. Co-hosted